



RECOMMENDATION LETTERS

BY MIGHTIER SWORD



WHAT ARE RECOMMENDATION LETTERS?

- ❑ Recommendation letters, or reference letters, are documents in which a recommender assesses the attributes, values and personalities of the individual being referred to.



SIGNIFICANCE OF RECOMMENDATION LETTERS

- ❑ Recommendation letters serve as extra layers of information to the admission officers, letting them know who and how a student is within a classroom and outside of the classroom, giving them clues to whether an applicant is a great fit for an institution of higher learning.



PARTS OF A RECOMMENDATION LETTER

- ☐ **Introduction**
- ☐ **Body**
- ☐ **Conclusion**



THE INTRODUCTION

- The introduction mentions the capacities in which the recommender(school counsellor/teacher) knew the student.
- It serves to answer how long they have known the student and where specifically.

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- It also highlights a trait of the student, and sets the tone for what is to be mentioned in the recommendation.



EXAMPLE OF AN INTRODUCTION

It is with great honor that I recommend Omar Kasera for admission into your institution. I am the guidance counselor at St. Charles Lwanga High School. It is in this capacity that I knew Omar while he schooled here. Omar joined our institution under a rigorous competitive admission process, managing to stand out among the ninety thousand students who sought admission into the school. When Omar finished his grade twelve studies, he excelled in his academics. Due to his outstanding GPA, exemplary extracurricular profile, leadership pursuits and community engagement, Omar was among our overall Valedictorians.



BODY

- The body of the recommendation consists of three or four paragraphs, specifying and elaborating on a particular trait.
- It is in the body that the recommendation stands out.



In class, Omar was not only attentive but also active, especially in mathematics class, one of his favorite subjects. I loved the way he used to explain some mathematical concepts and present his work. This earned him the nickname 'Pythagoras' among his peers. He used to push himself beyond what was taught in class and do extra assignments. As a result, he made fewer and fewer errors in his calculations. This resulted in marvelous grades in the subject. He also loved to initiate discussions in class during math hours. That, he believed, would help them improve their retention skills which would result in better grades. Truly, Omar was reliable and devoted, values that were helpful to him and his peers.



APPROACHING THE BODY

As you approach the body, remember to:

- Dedicate each body paragraph to a particular trait. If you mention a student is an active member of a class, let that paragraph demonstrate the attentiveness of the student.

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- Use anecdotes to make the recommendation as vivid as possible. Anecdotes seek to answer the the what, where, when, how and possibly give a why.

Through her outspoken nature, Rania livened up our class discussions. She exemplifies charisma and unmatched prowess when it comes to debates and discussions. On one occasion during discussions with seniors on Chinua Achebe's *'Things Fall Apart'*, the seniors all argued that colonialism was the root cause of Africa's flotsam and jetsam. Rania, however, took a contrarian perspective that angered her colleagues but blessed them with the view of a different perspective. She cautioned the seniors against having a victim's mentality, reminding them that while the past is hard to bear it is the past. Before she could finish, a senior was affirming indeed that Africans were victims of injustices like slavery. Rania rebutted the senior reminding her how fellow African chiefs and kings aided in the process of slavery when they would raid rival villages and sell the males to their masters. The senior was left dumbfounded. I always looked forward to hearing what Rania's views were on thematic concerns addressed in our set texts. It is her mastery of content, calmness in the midst of rejoinders in debate and discussions that make me reminisce about Rania as one of the few outstanding students of English I have ever taught.

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- Use of power statements may sometimes offer a breakthrough. Power statements demonstrate what a would be like at the institutions, while not being institution-specific.

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CONCLUSION

The conclusion gives a general perspective of what the recommender thinks the student will be in the future and the promise of personal and intellectual growth.



EXAMPLE OF A CONCLUSION

I am confident that Samuel will look to bloom wherever he is planted and demonstrate the need to empower your community as well through his inclusive personality. You have my utmost assurance on that. He holds a lot of promise, which I know you will all collectively realize. I will miss him, though.



CATEGORIES OF RECOMMENDATIONS

- **Counsellor Recommendation**
- **Teacher Recommendations**



COUNSELLOR RECOMMENDATION

- The counsellor recommendation speaks of your involvement outside of class and your impact on a school or greater community.
- They speak of your national academic profile, extra-curricular engagement and community activities.

Koech was the most outspoken student of his class. He was always confident in airing his views to those he engaged with. Whether it was at the debate club, class and house meeting or the school assembly, he raised concerns on important issues affecting the school. The most notable, however, was marshalling his class to be an exemption in the school by becoming the first class in the history of our institution to top the nation. On one Thursday morning during a meeting with the form principal, Koech spoke passionately about the significance of names and whether or not his peers wanted their names to have remembrance. The veracity of his arguments that the class should stop focusing on the past or the future, and only attack ruthlessly the present in my opinion helped the class to elope as the top class in Kenya. It is his outspoken nature that made him selected as a junior to join the debate club which previously comprised only seniors. Here, Koech's role in the team as a third speaker was to finalise the team's arguments, dotting the i's and crossing the f's. While most debaters defended their arguments like they were in a courtroom, Koech took a contrarian approach. He had the courage to embrace the truths of the opposing side before he went on to formulate his own arguments. His most iconic moment was quoting Biblical Joshua's quote '*Choose ye today*' when summarising his arguments, leaving the audience and judges to ponder over what he had just said. He excelled as a debater, as their debate team won the Rift Valley region and national edition of the Great Debaters Contest. This was such a great feat for our institution, which had never stepped on the national debate podium for a while. On an individual note, Koech was honored as the fifth best male debater and second best researcher. I am sure Koech's outspoken nature and openness will serve him in your institution's quest for truth.



TEACHER RECOMMENDATIONS

- Teacher recommendations are meant to speak about a student's attributes and personalities within a class.
- They are subject specific and serve as important clues to admission officers about how a student views learning and their approach to it.

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- They should mention your intellectual curiosity within said subject, how you interacted and collaborated with members of the class on say assignments, how your presence impacted the class and how could be you helped the teacher.



INTRODUCTIONS OF TEACHER RECOMMENDATIONS

- Sometimes the introduction of teacher recommendations can be an awesome way of standing out from the get go of the recommendation. This can be done through allusions to concepts or topics in the said subject, and relating them to who a student is.



PHYSICS RECOMMENDATION

Most students nowadays lack genuine passion in their approach to learning Physics. 'K constant' is the term I peg such students. Nuwagaba Brian, however, was not a 'K constant'. I regard him as one of the exceptional physics students of his class and an outstanding scientist in the Science club as he continuously demonstrated a good grasp of content beyond the typical syllabus. For instance, he used the concept of entanglement in quantum physics to explain how light travels from the source, to the object then to the eye, elaborating how all three exist in relation to each other. This ability to learn beyond curriculum made him an invaluable asset in my class.



BIOLOGY RECOMMENDATION

It is with great pleasure that I recommend Ruth Sanyu for admission into your institution. There was an osmotic potential about Ruth, as depicted by her ability to be porous in consuming knowledge while also sharing the knowledge she had gained. She was the Biology representative for her class and would teach her fellow classmates challenging topics.



GEOGRAPHY RECOMMENDATION

Few students stand out on the horizon of my memory like Mars at perihelion. Moli, is one such student whose memories resurface. Moli was a philomath when it came to learning physical geography and this never failed to show in our interactions. From her outspoken nature, meticulousness and passionate approach to learning, she was a beautiful mind to cultivate and interact with. I am more than privileged to be recommending her for admission to your institution.



INTELLECTUAL CURIOSITY

- Teacher recommendation will more often than not mention your said intellectual curiosity, within a subject and demonstrate possibly a superior intellectual edge over your peers. Mention the achievements within and outside the class, but they should be related to said subject.

Collins was an amalgam of high intellectual curiosity. His assorted and diversified interests always made him crave for more knowledge. It is in this that he utilized every resource in his environment to heighten his depth of knowledge. For example, he wasn't scared of bulky Physics textbooks that expounded on topics beyond our institutional level. Most of the time, the formulas were bombastic and he brought them onto me to help him understand them. I assisted him with the ones I could. He, however, never despaired on the ones that were beyond my level. He went to the computer and through various open coursewares posted by various institutions on youtube, he would try to understand the formulas. My colleagues and I grew fond of his presence and persistence. It is his curiosity that I believe gave him a superior intellectual edge in Physics. I was pleased when he participated in our school's yearly Physics Contest as a junior, a contest previously dominated by seniors. He wrestled with seniors for the top spot as the best student, and he would occasionally miss by just a point. Despite missing severally, this was an achievement as a junior. When he became a senior, he undoubtedly earned his position as the top student in Physics. Among his classmates, he would maintain his streak as the Physics subject champion in every exam. When the national exams were done, Collins emerged as the overall top student in Physics with a score of 97. This feat made me proud to have been his Physics instructor. He managed to reaffirm his spot as the Physics subject champion, and because he scored 97, he won the Dean of Science Award in Physics. Collins was one of our most dedicated science students. Therefore, when I nominate him, it is my belief that he will perfectly fit into your STEM program.

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- When mentioning superior intellectual edge too, a teacher can specify which branch of the subject a student was brighter in, in relation to the specific course they seek.
 - For example, somebody seeking to study civil engineering, a geography recommendation would say they were superior in physical geography.

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- An applicant seeking electrical engineering could have his physics recommendation say he was superior in electricity and magnetism.
 - A telecommunications engineering application- waves(Physics)
 - An environmental engineering application- Ecology(Biology) and Human Geography
 - Mechanical Engineering-Mechanics(Physics)
 - Chemical Engineering- Organic Chemistry(Chemistry)
 - Computer and Data Science- Statistics(Mathematics)



SPECIFICITY IN RECOMMENDATIONS

**LET THE ADMISSIONS OFFICERS
KNOW THE TEACHER
RECOMMENDING YOU IS IN SAID
SUBJECT**

During Physics practicals, it came to my knowledge that Collins possessed rigorous analytical skills. Using the first-hand knowledge I had given them in class, she would usually understand what an experiment was aiming at and establish relationships between and among investigated experimental variables. I once administered an experiment on Hooke's law of elasticity to determine the effect of force on elastic materials. The concept demanded an airtight analysis of the experimental variables which was force, the invariable which was elasticity and the apparatus set before them. I expected the class to draw a rising curve, insinuating that deformity on a material is directly proportional to the force applied on the material. The students however got a straight line instead of a curve. It was Collins who sought after me and told me that the weights used to apply the force were all equal therefore the deformity effect was the same creating a straight line effect instead of a flat curve. I was elated and told Collins to announce to everybody to approach the lab technician and request for varying weights. This makes me believe she will be a leader in academia who can thrive in experimentation-based research teams.

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- Use of specific vocabulary e.g wet or dry lab experiments for science subjects, fieldwork say for geography, debates for English.
 - Mention of specific topics that a student was fond of, found challenging or tutored other students in.



IMPACT ON CLASS

- Never fail to demonstrate impact on class.
- Impact can vary and can be through tutoring your classmates, leading instruction when the teacher was not around, giving your classmates a new of approaching problems and your presence.

Faith was not originally a good student in poetry. She would come for consultations in my office no matter what she had scored to share what was the reasoning behind her answers whether wrong or correct. She would borrow anthologies from my office and go read them all. When she returned them after finishing, she had grasped the reasoning behind various poems by being in the shoes of the persona. Once when she borrowed Rudyard Kipling's *Toomai of the Elephants*, Faith envisioned himself as the persona, swallowing all of her miseries and facing the day head-on. I learnt that Faith eagerly wanted to excel in poetry and pushed herself to that effect by reading multiple poems from different authors in different eras. That saw her eventually become an excellent student in poetry and essay writing. I guessed by looking at the whole landscape of poetry, she had found means of navigation to excellence in the field. **She inspired other members of the class to approach poetry by getting exposed to various poetic verses.** On one occasion when we were motivating her class, I remember he was called to give a vote of thanks which she did very well. However, she iced the cake by presenting to us *'Invictus'* by William Ernest Henley off her head. All eyes were glued to her, ears listening as she presented line after line of the poem. The result was expected, as teachers and students stood up clapping for her as the poem had aligned with the agenda that had us gathered all there. I know Faith may face academic difficulties in your institution. However, I trust in her ability to approach the difficulties and solve them through her curious nature and willingness to get exposed to resources that may aid him.



UNIVERSAL TRAITS

- Make sure the traits they speak about align with your application theme. If say you are applying with a STEM theme, attributes such as collaboration in labs or seeking STEM avenues such as Engineering Fairs can be a boost.
- For humanities/social sciences themes, attributes such as ability to hold meaningful discussions goes a long way.

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- There are however universal values that admissions officers always want to hear. They include:
 - Intellectual curiosity
 - Socialness
 - Community engagement/service
 - Kindness